

“HE EVERYWHERE SOUGHT EXCUSES FOR STIRRING UP WAR.”

Livy, from *Histories* book I, xxi, on Tullus Hostilius, third King of Rome

IN CHINA, THE CITY OF LUOYANG HAD FALLEN TO THE SHEN in 771 BCE, and the Western Zhou capital was transferred east to Chengzhou. From there, the Eastern Zhou dynasty presided over the **fragmentation of China** into as many as 148 states. From around 700 BCE the Zhou were ruled by puppet-emperors, while real power lay with the **ba** (“senior one”) among nearby states. Under **Qi Huan Gong** (r. 685–643 BCE), the state of Qi had supremacy. After Huan Gong’s death the **competition for power** between his five sons weakened Qi, and **Jin Wen Gong** (r. 685–643 BCE), the ruler of Jin, rose to become ba. By the end of the century, power in China alternated among the **states of Qi, Jin, Qin, and Chu**.



Nubian Pharaoh
Taharqa ruled Egypt for 19 years before an Assyrian invasion forced him to return to Nubia in 671 BCE.

7 THE NUMBER OF KINGS OF ROME

In Italy, the **city-state of Rome** was beginning to acquire an urban heart, and the **first forum** was constructed. The second king of Rome, **Numa Pompilius** (r. 716–674 BCE) is believed to have established the main Roman priesthoods and a calendar.

In the Near East, the **Assyrians continued their expansion**, confronting Egypt, whose intermittent support for rebels against Assyrian rule in Syria had long been a source of tension. In 671 BCE, the Assyrian ruler Esarhaddon invaded, **capturing the Egyptian royal capital** of Memphis. However, Assyrian control over Egypt was weak, and the Nubian pharaoh **Taharqa** drove the invaders out.

The **Etruscans** expanded southward from modern Tuscany and Umbria around 700 BCE. Their language remains undeciphered, but lavish tombs indicate a **rich material culture**. During their expansion, the Etruscans founded cities such as Capua, but came into **conflict** with Greek colonies and with Rome. Although more powerful at first, the Etruscans were **politically disunited**, and a **long series of wars** with the Romans turned against them.



Pyramids from the cemetery at Nuri, Sudan, which was the burial site of the Napatan and Meroitic kings from around 650 BCE.

IT TOOK A CONCERTED CAMPAIGN BY ASHURBANIPAL (r. 668–627 BCE)

in 664–663 BCE to defeat the Egyptians who had rebelled against Assyrian rule, and to push Assyrian control as far south as Thebes (modern Luxor). This was not the last rebellion against the Assyrians—only ten years later, the vassal king of Saïs, **Psammetichus I** (r. 664–610 BCE), revolted against his Assyrian masters, driving them out and founding the 26th Dynasty, under which **Egypt’s independence was restored**. After the final collapse of Assyrian power, in 609 BCE, Egypt was able to establish a foothold in Palestine under **Pharaoh Necho II** (610–595 BCE).

In Greece, the **rise** to preeminence of a number of **city states**, notably **Athens, Sparta, and Corinth**, began. In Corinth, a new type of ruler, the “tyrant,” emerged with the overthrow of the Bacchiadae kings in 658 BCE.

“TAHARQA THE GODLESS CAME OUT TO TAKE EGYPT.”

Ashurbanipal’s account of the conquest of Egypt, 664 BCE

The new ruler, **Cypselus** (reign c. 657–627 BCE) relied on force of personality rather than divine sanction, and established a dynasty under which Corinth enjoyed a **seven-decade period of dominance**, creating colonies throughout the western Mediterranean.

On the fringes of the Greek world, in western Asia Minor, the **kingdom of Lydia** was increasing in power under **Gyges** (685–647 BCE), its first great king. He allied with Ashurbanipal of Assyria to see off a joint threat to their two lands by Cimmerian raiders in 668–665 BCE, but then

assisted Psammetichus I of Egypt in his revolt against the Assyrians. He also adopted an aggressive stance towards his neighbors, the Ionian Greeks of Miletus and Smyrna.

According to Japanese tradition, the first emperor, **Jimmu Tenno**, a descendant of the sun goddess **Amaterasu**, ascended to the throne in 660 BCE. The stories of his migration from southern Honshu eastward to establish his kingdom near Nara are legendary, but may echo real events of the Japanese **Yayoi** period after 100 BCE, when tribal chieftains began to **consolidate their territories**.

The third king of Rome, **Tullus Hostilius** (r. 673–642 BCE) was more martially inclined than his predecessor Numa Pompilius, and

ASHURBANIPAL (r. 668–627 BCE)

Ashurbanipal initially shared rule over Assyria with his brother, Shamash-shuma-ukin. After defeating his brother’s revolt in 648 BCE he greatly expanded the Assyrian domains. As well as annexing Egypt, he attacked Elam, sacking its capital, Susa, in 647 BCE. His latter years saw none of the military successes of his early reign. At his death a dispute between his two sons further weakened the Assyrian Empire.



30,000 THE NUMBER OF CLAY TABLETS UNCOVERED IN ASHURBANIPAL’S LIBRARY

